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Looking Both Ways (1973–1979)

> *The main ideological and political justification for US aid was to build up democratic India on a counter-balance against China. With Sino-US rapprochement, this justification is no longer there.*
>
> —Indian intelligence assessment, 1972[1]

> *It is easy to overestimate the potential of the Indo-US relationship. India has very little to offer us in a tangible sense. We, too, have relatively little to offer India.… Neither of us poses a threat to the other, hence there is no great urgency to the relationship on either side.*
>
> —Thomas Thornton, National Security Council staff, 1977[2]

It was August 1976, two years after Nixon had resigned and a few months before his successor Gerald Ford would be defeated by Jimmy Carter. In Washington, two men sat across from each other to discuss the lack of progress in US-India relations since that attempt at a reset. It was perhaps a fitting reflection of the relationship that each man was known for having a preference for the other country's rival—Kissinger for China, and Indian ambassador to Washington T. N. Kaul for the Soviet Union.

Kissinger said it was "curious"; the two countries had "no major conflicts of interest, no major problems." Kaul added that they had "no conflict of goals" either.[3] It was not the lack of a high-level dialogue—the